

THE BORROWED CHRIST

*Biblical Prophets in the Qur'ān and Their Syriac-Aramaic
Legendary Substrates*

A Historical-Critical and Christological Assessment

JOSHUA B. LINGEL

Founder and President, i2 Ministries
Mission Muslim World University

Scholarly Monograph Series · 2027

Introduction: The Investigation

Everybody Wants Him

Begin with a fact so ordinary that almost nobody stops to find it strange.

Every major religion in the world has an opinion about Jesus of Nazareth. Not a passing reference but a position, worked out, defended, and taught. And nearly every new religious movement of the last two centuries has done the same.

Consider the range of it.

Islam makes him a prophet, born of a virgin, the Messiah, faultless, a worker of miracles who spoke from the cradle to defend his mother and breathed life into birds he had shaped from clay. It denies that he is the Son of God, and denies that he was crucified at all, teaching instead that it was made to appear so and that God raised him up alive. It denies the Trinity, and the Trinity it denies has Mary in it, not the Holy Spirit (Q 5:116).

Then the traditions finish him. He returns at the end of days to break the cross, kill the swine, and abolish the tax under which Christians are permitted to remain Christians. He rules as a Muslim, marries, dies a natural death, and is buried beside Muḥammad at Medina. He is also given a station in Muḥammad's night ascension — the second of seven heavens, below Joseph, Aaron, Moses, and Abraham. Chapter Nine sets that out in full.

The Ahmadiyya movement, following Mirza Ghulam Ahmad's *Masīḥ Hindūstān Mein*, *Jesus in India*, has him survive the cross, travel east, and die at a hundred and twenty in Kashmir, where a shrine at Roza Bal in Srinagar is shown to visitors as his tomb. Ahmad's evidence was local legend and a set of footprint carvings, not a first-century document.

Latter-day Saints (Mormons) have him appear in the Americas after the resurrection, descending from heaven before a crowd of some two thousand five hundred at Bountiful,⁴ showing them the wounds and commissioning twelve disciples in the New World. They teach that he and Lucifer were spirit brothers in a premortal existence, and that faithful men may themselves become gods. They expect him to return to Independence, Missouri, designated in an 1831 revelation as the site of Zion and the New Jerusalem. The source for all of it is not a first-century document but the Book of Mormon, published by Joseph Smith in 1830 — eighteen centuries after the events it narrates — from golden plates that no one may examine.

Jehovah's Witnesses identify him as Michael the archangel, the first created being, and render John 1:1 so that the Word was *a god*.⁵ They also hold that he has already returned — invisibly. Charles Taze Russell originally placed that invisible presence in 1874; the Watchtower later moved it to 1914, where it remains. The second coming, on this account, is an event that has occurred and that no one saw.

Christian Science separates the man Jesus from "the Christ," an eternal divine idea⁶ he demonstrated rather than embodied.

The Bahá'í Faith counts him among the Manifestations of God — genuine, honored, and superseded.

The Unification Church teaches that his mission failed: he died before he could marry⁷ and establish the perfect family, leaving the work to another.

Theosophy and the New Age make him an ascended master, one initiate among many, sometimes distinguished from a separate cosmic Christ who overshadowed him.

⁴ *Book of Mormon*, 3 Nephi 11:8–12; *Doctrine and Covenants* 57:1–3 on Independence, Missouri.

⁵ *New World Translation*, John 1:1; *Watch Tower* doctrine on the invisible presence, revised from 1874 to 1914. See Bowman, *Understanding Jehovah's Witnesses* (Grand Rapids: Baker, 1991).

⁶ Mary Baker Eddy, *Science and Health with Key to the Scriptures* (Boston: Christian Science Board of Directors, 1875), 26–34, 332–34.

⁷ Sun Myung Moon, *Divine Principle, part I, chap. 4, on the incompleteness of Jesus's mission* (New York: Holy Spirit Association for the Unification of World Christianity, 1973).

Hindu reformers in the line of Vivekananda receive him warmly as an avatar,⁸ a genuine descent of the divine — and precisely one of several.

Buddhist teachers such as Thích Nhất Hạnh have honored him as a bodhisattva, a fully awakened being of great compassion.

Rastafari locate the returned Christ in the person of Haile Selassie I.⁹

Scientology treats him as an implanted image, a fiction inserted into the human mind.¹⁰

And alongside the religions stand the manufactured gospels. Nicolas Notovitch published a *Life of Saint Issa* in Paris in 1894, claiming to have found at the Hemis monastery in Ladakh the record of Jesus's lost years in India. Max Müller demanded the manuscript. It was never produced; the abbot of Hemis, questioned independently, denied both that Notovitch had ever visited and that any such text existed. Levi Dowling issued *The Aquarian Gospel of Jesus the Christ* in 1908, transcribed, he said, from the Akashic records on the ether. And the *Gospel of Barnabas*, which circulates today throughout the Muslim world in a dozen languages, is treated at length in Chapter Ten because it is the one text most often pressed on Christians as decisive, and because the case against it is overwhelming.

The Thing They All Have in Common

Now notice what is missing from every entry on that list.

Not one of the religions on that list derives its Jesus from the documents in which Jesus is actually attested.

Not one of them argues from Mark, written within a generation of the events, or from the creed Paul received within five years of the crucifixion and quotes at 1 Corinthians 15, or from the eyewitness names embedded in the

⁸ Swami Vivekananda, "Christ, the Messenger," in *Complete Works* (Calcutta: Advaita Ashrama), 4:138–53.

⁹ On Rastafari Christology, see Ennis B. Edmonds, *Rastafari: A Very Short Introduction* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2012), 31–46.

¹⁰ L. Ron Hubbard, Class VIII lectures (1968), on the R6 implant.

Gospel narratives, or from the Aramaic prayer that Palestinian Jews addressed to Jesus so early that Paul left it untranslated in a Greek letter.

Every one of them reaches somewhere else. To a seventh-century revelation. To a nineteenth-century vision. To a monastery scroll no one can produce. To a channeled transcript. To a spiritual insight that requires no manuscript at all.

They all want him. None of them will take him from his own witnesses.

Look again at what each one reached for instead. A Himalayan monastery that turned out to be empty of the manuscript. A shrine in Srinagar and some marks on a stone. Golden plates no one may examine. A transcript said to be read off the ether. A revelation in seventh-century Arabia to an audience with no Bible in its language.

Every one of them had to go outside the first century to find the Jesus they wanted. That is the single most important pattern in the history of religion, and almost nobody names it.

And that is not an accident, because his own witnesses say something no religion on earth can absorb without ceasing to be itself. They say that this man forgave sins on his own authority. That he accepted worship from monotheistic Jews and did not correct them. That he applied to himself the words by which the God of Israel identifies himself in Isaiah. That he was crucified under a named Roman prefect, buried in a known tomb, and raised on the third day and that men who had every reason to keep quiet went to their deaths insisting they had seen it.

A prophet can be added to any system. An avatar can be added, an archangel can be added, an ascended master can be added. *The Jesus of the first century cannot be added to anything.* He does not fit inside a larger frame, because he claims to be the frame. That is precisely why he must be re-sourced before he can be received — and re-sourcing him is what every movement on that list has done.

Why This Book Presses So Hard

This is not a quarrel between institutions. It is a question about a person, and the question is being asked in real time in living rooms and dormitories and

mosques and churches all over the world. It is being asked in love to people who need answers to their decisions.

So, I have written plainly. Where the evidence is strong, I have said so, and where my own case is weak, I have said that too. But I have not softened the conclusion to make it easier to receive, because what is at stake here will not be served by a book that is careful about everything except the truth.

If the Jesus of the Qur'an is not the Jesus of the first century — and what follows demonstrates, document by document and date by date, that he is not — then a quarter of the human race has been given a portrait of Christ assembled from stories the church itself had already set aside as fiction. Not maliciously. Not by conspiracy. By the ordinary process by which a story crosses a desert without a text to correct it. But given nonetheless.

And what has been taken away in the exchange is not a doctrine. It is a cross that actually happened, a debt that was actually paid, a tomb that was actually empty, and a God who does not merely command from a distance but comes, and bleeds, and dies, and rises, and gives himself to be known.

To My Muslim Reader

I have spent thirty years among your people. I have been fed at your tables, welcomed into your homes, and shown a hospitality my own culture has largely forgotten. I write as someone who holds you in real affection, and who thinks this question worth your time because I take you seriously as a thinker.

So, I have given you my best work. Every source is cited so you can check it. Where the evidence is strong, I say so; where my own case is weakest, I say that too. Many of the scholars I rely on are not Christians and have no stake in your conclusions or mine.

I ask one thing: examine the dates. When were the Christian documents written, and when do the stories in your own tradition first appear? Which of the two can produce witnesses? And why does the miracle most associated with ʿĪsā — the birds of clay — appear first in a Greek storybook written for children a hundred years after Jesus died, in a book no church has ever accepted?

I am not asking you to abandon truth but to follow it, because I believe that at the end of that road stands not an argument but a Person: the one crucified under Pontius Pilate, buried, and raised on the third day, who is alive, and who is far more merciful than you may have been told.

Whatever you conclude, you have my respect for having read this far.

A Road Outside Bethlehem, About the Year 450

Begin here, because everything that follows runs through this place.

Three miles south of Jerusalem, on the road to Bethlehem, there stands an octagonal church built around a rock. Pilgrims call it the Kathisma — the Seat — because tradition says Mary rested on that stone when the journey became too much for her. On her feast day the church fills. Lamps are lit. A deacon reads, and then a cantor sings the story the pilgrims came to hear: how the mother of God, exhausted and in pain, was refreshed when a palm tree bent its branches down to her, and how water broke from the ground at its roots.

Nobody in that building thinks they are hearing Scripture. The story is not in Matthew. It is not in Luke. It is a beloved embellishment, four centuries young, and the bishops who permit it know precisely what it is.

The pilgrims go home. Some of them go a long way home — down the incense roads, through Ghassānid country, into the tent camps and market towns of Arabia, where the story is told again in Syriac, and then in Arabic, to people who have never seen a Gospel in their own language and never will.

Two hundred years later a voice recites, in an Arabic that no one has yet written a grammar for: *And the pangs of childbirth drove her to the trunk of a palm tree... your Lord has placed a rivulet beneath you. And shake toward yourself the trunk of the palm tree; it will drop upon you ripe dates.*

And it is no longer an embellishment. It is the word of God, and to doubt it is unbelief.

That journey — from a shrine on the Bethlehem Road to a revelation in Arabia — is the subject of these pages. It can be traced. It has been traced, by

scholars with no interest in the Christian faith. And what it means is the question I intend to press without flinching.

Set two portraits side by side.

In the first portrait, Jesus of Nazareth a Galilean Jew of the first century — is executed by Roman crucifixion under a prefect we can name, Pontius Pilate, in a year we can approximate, around AD 30, outside a city we can excavate. Within three to five years of that execution — a figure that commands broad agreement across the confessional spectrum — a fixed creedal formula is circulating that says he died, was buried, was raised, and appeared to named witnesses who were still alive and could be questioned. Within twenty years his followers are singing hymns that apply to him the one passage in Isaiah where God refuses to share his glory with another. Within a generation, Jewish monotheists in Jerusalem are praying to him in Aramaic.

In the second, a prophet named ʿĪsā speaks from his cradle to defend his mother, fashions birds from clay and breathes them into flight, is not crucified but only made to appear so, is raised alive to God, and will return to break the cross and abolish the tax on the People of the Book. He denies, in his own reported words, that he ever told anyone to worship him or his mother.

These are not two interpretations of one man. They are two different men, separated by six hundred years. Only one of them left evidence behind.

The question is where the other one came from. The answer, traced document by document across the chapters that follow, is that he was assembled from children's stories, from a shrine on the Bethlehem Road, from a heresy a bishop had refuted four hundred years earlier — and that the assembly can be dated.

What Is at Stake

Four things are denied, and each of them is load-bearing.

The Trinity. The New Testament names Father, Son, and Holy Spirit together, or places the Son or Spirit in explicitly divine relation to the Father, in

over six hundred passages.¹¹ This is not a doctrine hidden in a proof text and inflated at Nicaea. It is the connective tissue of the corpus.

The eternal Sonship. Q 112:3 declares that God neither begets nor is begotten. If there is no eternal Son there is no eternal Father, and the first two words Jesus taught his disciples to pray rest on a relation adopted in time rather than on the eternal life of God.

The crucifixion. Q 4:157 denies the best-attested fact in the life of Jesus — conceded by Roman and Jewish sources, and by the entire skeptical wing of modern scholarship.

The atonement. There is no sacrifice for sin in the Qur’ān, no mediator, no priesthood, no blood. Every soul bears its own burden, and the outcome is disclosed to no one.

Remove these and what remains is a Jesus who cannot save anyone, a gospel that is not news, and a Spirit who is an angel. That is what Paul was warning about, and it is why the question worth pressing is provenance rather than sentiment.

¹¹ The catalogue and counting methodology are set out in Appendix D. On the Trinitarian grammar of the New Testament generally, see Gordon D. Fee, *Pauline Christology* (Peabody: Hendrickson, 2007), 586–93; Wesley Hill, *Paul and the Trinity* (Grand Rapids: Eerdmans, 2015), 1–40.